

Jane Eyre

by Charlotte Brontë

Selected Chapters (XXIII - XXV)

Chapter XXIII

A splendid Midsummer shone over England: skies so pure, suns so radiant as were then seen in long succession, seldom favour even singly our wave-girt land. It was as if a band of Italian days had come from the South, like a flock of glorious passenger birds, and lighted to rest them on the cliffs of Albion.

I was in the garden. Mr. Rochester had been walking there earlier; I had seen him enter the house. I thought I was safe, and I went down to the orchard. But he was there. He had not gone in. He stood by the wicket, looking at a great moth, a sphinx moth, causing it to flutter.

"Jane, come and look at this fellow," said he.

I obeyed. He looked at me, and I looked at the moth. The trees were laden with ripening fruit; the garden was beautiful.

"You have examined him long enough," said he. "The creature is a real elf. He reminds me of you." He paused, and then added, "Jane, I must have you for my own—entirely my own. Will you be mine? Say yes, quickly."

"Mr. Rochester, let me look at your face: turn to the moonlight."

"Why?"

"Because I want to read your countenance—turn!"

"There! you will find it hardly more legible than a crumpled, scratched page. Read on: only make haste, for I suffer."

His face was very much agitated and very much flushed, and there were strong workings in the features when he turned them to the light.

"Oh, Jane, you torture me!" he exclaimed. "With that searching and yet faithful and generous look, you torture me!"

"How can I do that? If you are true, and your offer real, my only feelings to you must be gratitude and devotion—they cannot torture."

"Gratitude!" he ejaculated; and added wildly—"Jane, accept me quickly. Say, Edward—give me my name—Edward—I will marry you."

"Are you in earnest? Do you truly love me? Do you sincerely wish me to be your wife?"

"I do; and if an oath is necessary to satisfy you, I swear it."

"Then, sir, I will marry you."

"Edward—my little wife!"

"Dear Edward!"

"Come to me—come to me entirely now," said he; and added, in his deepest tone, speaking in my ear as his cheek was laid on mine, "Make my happiness—I will make yours."

"God pardon me!" he subjoined ere long; "and man meddle not with me: I have her, and will hold her."

"There is no one to meddle, sir. I have no kindred to interfere."

"No—that is the best of it," he said.

The wind roared high in the great trees which embowered us; but a mile off, and as far out of the garden, we heard nothing but the soft sighing of the breeze. A bolt of lightning tore the sky, and the thunder crashed. The rain rushed down. We ran to the house.

In the morning, the great horse-chestnut at the bottom of the orchard had been struck by lightning, and half of it split away.

Chapter XXIV

The day following the proposal was a day of bliss. Mr. Rochester was all kindness, all tenderness. He seemed to have no thought but for my happiness.

"Jane," said he, "you must have some new clothes. We will go to Millcote this morning."

I protested. I had no desire to be dressed like a doll. But he insisted. We went to Millcote, and he ordered silk and satin. I would not have them. I chose a sober grey stuff and a black silk. He was annoyed, but I stood firm.

"You are a tyrant," he said, smiling. "You are a little tyrant."

"And you, sir, are a sultan," I replied. "I will not be part of your seraglio."

He laughed, and his eyes sparkled. The month of courtship had begun. It was a time of intense happiness, but also of struggle. I had to maintain my independence. I had to remind him—and myself—that I was poor, obscure, and plain, while he was rich, powerful, and handsome.

"I am your plain, Quakerish governess," I told him.

"You are my elf, my sprite, my life," he answered.

One evening, he asked me to sing. I sang a song of love and longing. He listened, entranced.

"Jane," he said, "you are unique. You are like no one else. When we are married, we will travel. We will go to Europe. You will see the world."

"I shall be happy anywhere with you, sir."

"And I with you, Jane. My life has been dark and lonely. You are the light that has come into it. You are my salvation."

I looked at him. There was a shadow in his eyes, a hint of some past sorrow or sin. But I dismissed it. I loved him, and I trusted him.

"Promise me, Jane," he said suddenly, "that you will never leave me."

"I promise, sir. Unless..."

"Unless what?"

"Unless you cease to love me."

"That will never happen," he declared passionately. "My love for you is as deep as the sea and as enduring as the mountains."

And so the days passed, bringing us closer to the wedding day.

Chapter XXV

The month of courtship had wasted: its very last hours were being numbered. There was no putting off the day that advanced—the bridal day; and all preparations for its arrival were complete. I, at least, had nothing more to do. My trunks were packed, locked, corded, ranged in a row along the wall of my little chamber.

It was the night before the wedding. Mr. Rochester had been away for a day on business. I was alone in the house, save for the servants. The wind was howling outside, and the rain beat against the windows. I felt a strange sense of foreboding.

I went out into the orchard to look at the riven chestnut tree. It stood there, black and blasted, a melancholy sight.

When Mr. Rochester returned, I ran to meet him. I was trembling.

"Jane, what is the matter? You are pale as a ghost."

"I have had a dream, sir. A terrible dream."

"Tell me," he said, drawing me close.

"I dreamt that I was walking down a long road, carrying a child. The child was heavy and cried piteously. I tried to put it down, but it clung to me. And then I saw you, riding ahead of me. I called to you, but you did not hear. You rode on, and I was left behind in the darkness."

"It is but a dream, Jane. A nervous fancy."

"But there is more, sir. I woke up, and there was a light in my room. A woman was standing there."

"A woman?" His voice was sharp. "What woman?"

"I do not know. She was tall and large, with thick dark hair hanging down her back. She was dressed in white. She went to the mirror and took my wedding veil—the expensive one you bought for me—and put it on."

"And then?"

"She looked at herself in the glass. Her face was purple, bloated, and terrible. It was a vampire's face. She tore the veil in two, threw it on the floor, and trampled on it."

Mr. Rochester turned pale. He gripped my hands tightly.

"It must have been Grace Poole," he said, his voice unsteady. "She is a strange woman, eccentric. She must have been trying on the veil and tore it in a fit of jealousy."

"But the face, sir! It was not Grace Poole's face."

"It was a nightmare, Jane. Your imagination, heated by the events of the day, conjured up a phantom. Forget it. Tomorrow we shall be married, and no ghost or goblin shall part us."

He kissed me and sent me to bed. But I could not sleep. The image of the woman with the purple face haunted me. Who was she? And what did her appearance portend?

The morning of the wedding dawned grey and overcast.